CAST OF CHARACTERS

THE INVESTIGATORS

D.R. KAARTHIKEYAN (52): Head of the SIT

D.R. Kaarthikeyan is a lawyer-turned-police officer from the 1964 batch of the IPS. He was appointed to head the SIT by then Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar in consultation with the director of the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), Vijay Karan. Though not very high-profile at the time, Kaarthikeyan was chosen for the job for his managerial skills, varied experiences in non-police assignments attached to diplomatic missions and his wide network of influential people. He was known to be shrewd and intelligent, and knew how to deal with politicians. Rajiv Gandhi's assassination was a very sensitive case with political overtones.

In the SIT, his journey could not have been very smooth, given the nature of the task. But he stuck to it and succeeded in proving the guilty in the court of law and secured justice for the victims. Kaarthikeyan handled his team with care, supervised the progress of the investigation despite non-stop obstacles, visited Sonia Gandhi, Rajiv Gandhi's wife, in Delhi and briefed her on the progress of the investigation, faced the media onslaught with diplomatic replies and retained his uniform spotless with the same elan.

As time passed and the mastermind of the assassination, Sivarasan, remained elusive, Kaarthikeyan's reputation took a hit. In the final strike on Sivarasan at the Konanakunte hideout in Bangalore (now Bengaluru), Kaarthikeyan earned the wrath of the media and some fellow members for 'delaying the operation' and not allowing the National Security Guard (NSG) commandos to try and 'catch Sivarasan alive'. But Kaarthikeyan alone was definitely not empowered to take calls. CBI boss Vijay Karan was himself present and taking calls, at times bypassing Kaarthikeyan.